ITERA LAB

SPRING PROGRAMME 2027
UNDERSTAND BRUSSELS. BUILD YOUR OWN PATH.

LEARN. EXPERIENCE. ENGAGE.

IteraLab is an orientation programme for those who want to build a European career in Brussels.



WATCH THE VIDEO (1 MIN)
Click the image or scan the code

PROGRAMME I

12–17 APRIL 2027

Week 15

PROGRAMME II

24–29 MAY 2027

Week 21

PROGRAMME III

14–19 JUNE 2027

Week 24

WHY BRUSSELS

UNDERSTAND BRUSSELS. BUILD YOUR OWN PATH.

Every year thousands of students and young professionals look to Brussels as the place to build a career — in the European institutions, in companies, in trade associations, think tanks, NGOs, law firms, international organisations or the media.

Yet between an interest in Europe and an actual career in the European professional ecosystem there is often a gap that is hard to close. University provides solid theoretical grounding in how the European Union works, but rarely a sense of how Brussels functions as a working environment: where opportunities come from, how relationships of trust are built, which skills genuinely make a difference.

IteraLab exists to close that gap. Through an intensive career orientation programme built around the direct experience of the IteraLab Faculty, participants engage with professionals who work in the European ecosystem every day, and gain concrete tools to guide their own choices.

The Spring Programme 2027 does not teach Europe through theory. It guides participants through a complex professional environment, helping them identify the path that best fits their ambitions, skills and interests.

WHO IS AROUND THE INSTITUTIONS

The European institutions are the centre, but they are not the main employer. Around them lives an ecosystem that hires, every year, far more people.



This is the ecosystem the programme teaches you to read: ten modules, ten different vantage points.

THE PROGRAMME SPEAKERS.

Each edition is built around ten modules: the speakers confirmed for the Spring Programme 2027 are the ones listed here.



ALFREDO ALAGNA

CO-FOUNDER OF ITERALAB · FORMER EU OFFICIAL, EUROPEAN PARLIAMENT

He worked at the European Parliament for more than twenty-five years, first as a parliamentary assistant and then as an official in the Directorate-General for Communication, on information, communication and on projects and events aimed at students and young professionals. That experience is part of where the idea for IteraLab came from.



IGNAZIO CORRAO

SENIOR POLICY & ADVOCACY MANAGER, FEBA · FORMER MEP

He leads the policy and advocacy department of the European Food Banks Federation in Brussels, coordinating its advocacy strategy and institutional relations. A lawyer, he served two terms as a Member of the European Parliament from 2014 to 2024, working on human rights, development cooperation, industry and energy.



LORENZO COSTANTINO

SENIOR PARTNER, IDP EUROPEAN CONSULTANTS

He is Senior Partner at IDP European Consultants, a consulting and training firm specialised in EU funding programmes and financial instruments. An expert in European project design since 2008, he works on international partnerships and access to EU funding. He has been an external expert and evaluator for the European Commission, and advised the World Bank for fifteen years.



RAFFAELLA DE MARTE

HEAD OF THE SERVICES AND MEDIA UNIT, EUROPEAN PARLIAMENT

She has headed the European Parliament's Services and Media Unit since 2018, after an internal career as editorial coordinator and as press officer and web manager to the President of the European Parliament. She arrived in Brussels in 2004, working in the Council's press office, then for Members of the Parliament, and from 2007 to 2012 as Policy Adviser at CER.

THE PROGRAMME SPEAKERS.



MARCO FRANZA

ENERGY AND ATOMIC QUESTIONS EXPERT, PERMANENT REPRESENTATION OF ITALY TO THE EU

He has been the energy and atomic questions expert at the Italian Permanent Representation to the EU since 2023. He spent almost nine years at the European Commission, first as a seconded national expert at the Energy Directorate of DG RTD, and was Italy's delegate to the Nuclear Law Committee of the OECD Nuclear Energy Agency. He is a senior officer of ENEA.



GIACOMO MATTINÒ

INDEPENDENT CONSULTANT · FORMER HEAD OF UNIT, EUROPEAN COMMISSION

He spent more than thirty years as a permanent official of the European Commission, in the Directorate-General for Internal Market, Industry, Entrepreneurship and SMEs, close to fifteen of them in management roles, alongside work of growing responsibility in human resources. He now advises independently on EU affairs.



MATTEO MUSSINI

CO-FOUNDER OF ITERALAB · FOUNDING PARTNER, MUST & PARTNERS

Co-founder of a Brussels-based strategic consultancy working in public affairs and institutional relations between Italy and the EU. Educated at the London School of Economics, he supports companies and organisations in reading European decision-making.



ROBERTO PANICO

HEAD OF EU AFFAIRS, TERNA

From Brussels he leads the European institutional relations of Italy's electricity transmission operator, he acts as Secretary General of Gruppo d'Iniziativa Italiana and sits on the board of APRIl. He previously spent eleven years with the Eni group, where he was head of relations with the European Parliament.



ROBERTO ZANGRANDI

PARTNER, HIGHTECH PARTNERS · FORMER SECRETARY GENERAL, E.DSO

Partner at a Brussels-based executive search firm recruiting profiles in advanced technology and general management. Former Secretary General of E.DSO and head of Enel Group's European public affairs. His career also includes twelve years at Fiat and fifteen in economic journalism.

THE PROGRAMME

SIX DAYS, TEN MODULES.

Six days in Brussels, ten modules. Each one is led by the people who do that job every day, and covers what the work actually involves, who does it and how to get in.

THE EUROPEAN PARLIAMENT	Alfredo Alagna
THE PERMANENT REPRESENTATION AND THE COUNCIL	Marco Franza
THE EUROPEAN COMMISSION	Giacomo Mattinò
EU COMPETITIONS AND EPSO SELECTIONS	EU Careers Coach
PUBLIC AFFAIRS AND CONSULTANCY	Matteo Mussini
EU HEAD HUNTING AND THE JOB MARKET	Roberto Zangrandi
EU FUNDING AND PROJECT DESIGN	Lorenzo Costantino
IN-HOUSE LOBBYING: EU AFFAIRS INSIDE A COMPANY	Roberto Panico
EU JOURNALISM AND INSTITUTIONAL COMMUNICATION	Raffaella De Marte
NGOS AND EUROPEAN CIVIL SOCIETY	Ignazio Corrao

Two evening networking moments are part of every edition: a meeting with the IteraLab Faculty, and drinks in Place de Luxembourg — the social ritual of the Brussels ecosystem.

HOW IT WORKS

HOW AN ITERALAB SESSION WORKS.

An IteraLab session is not a lecture: it is a career orientation path built on a shared method, followed by the entire Faculty, designed to give participants realistic tools for entering the European job market.

1 THE SPEAKER'S PROFESSIONAL STORY

Studies, first jobs, arriving in Brussels, career choices, obstacles met and chances taken: real paths, rarely linear.

2 HOW THE SECTOR REALLY WORKS

The current role, daily responsibilities, counterparts, files being handled — with a practical case whenever possible.

3 WHAT RECRUITERS LOOK FOR

The technical and soft skills expected of a junior profile, and the most common mistakes in applications.

4 PRACTICAL ADVICE

CVs, motivation letters, LinkedIn, interviews, applications, networking and first professional steps.

5 QUESTIONS AND OPEN DISCUSSION

Roughly one third of every session is reserved for a direct exchange with participants.

THE EUROPEAN PARLIAMENT

ALFREDO ALAGNA

The role and powers of the European Parliament and the jobs that come with it.

The powers of the European Parliament within the European legislative process. How the administrative machine works in practice — officials, accredited and local assistants, political group staff, trainees — and how contracts and prospects differ. The Parliament's sensitive relationship with interest representatives and lobby groups.

IN THIS SESSION YOU WILL LEARN

- How a legislative file actually travels, from referral to adoption in Plenary
- The routes into the Parliament, and where and when to look for openings
- The Parliament's professional roles and their contracts
- How to build a credible application to an MEP or to the parliamentary administration

THE PERMANENT REPRESENTATION AND THE COUNCIL

MARCO FRANZA

How a Member State's position is built and how negotiation works inside the Council's working groups.

How the Council works and how a member state's position is formed. The Permanent Representation: what it does, who staffs it and how it relates to national administrations.

IN THIS SESSION YOU WILL LEARN

- How the Council works from the inside
- How a European compromise is built
- The main and lesser-known routes into the Permanent Representation
- The role of the seconded national expert

THE EUROPEAN COMMISSION

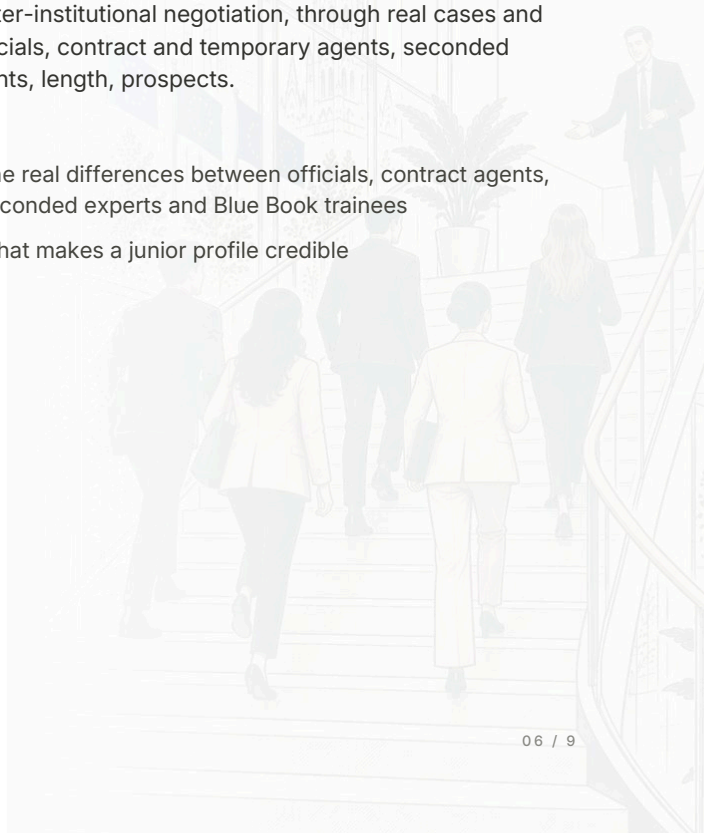
GIACOMO MATTINÒ

How a Directorate-General is organised, what a policy officer does and which entry routes exist beyond the competitions.

The structure: Cabinets, Directorates-General, Directorates, Units and horizontal services. The life of an initiative, from programming and consultation to impact assessment, adoption and inter-institutional negotiation, through real cases and the skills a Unit looks for. The professional profiles — AD and AST officials, contract and temporary agents, seconded national experts, trainees — and the Blue Book traineeship: requirements, length, prospects.

IN THIS SESSION YOU WILL LEARN

- How the Commission is organised internally
- How a legislative proposal comes about
- The real differences between officials, contract agents, seconded experts and Blue Book trainees
- What makes a junior profile credible



EU COMPETITIONS AND EPSO SELECTIONS

EU CAREERS COACH

How EPSO competitions work and how to build a realistic preparation.

Where and how to find information on EPSO competitions. The types of selection and the stages of a competition. The role and the methods of the European Personnel Selection Office in the selection process. A closer look at the CAST procedure for contract agents.

IN THIS SESSION YOU WILL LEARN

- How to write an application for an EPSO competition
- How the CAST procedure works, through a real simulation
- A preparation plan and a short to medium term strategy
- The most common mistakes made by EPSO candidates

PUBLIC AFFAIRS AND CONSULTANCY

MATTEO MUSSINI

What a public affairs firm actually does, how client relationships work and how careers progress in consultancy.

The Brussels consultancy market: who the players are, how large they are, how they sell. The daily work: legislative monitoring, briefings, stakeholder mapping, position papers, events. How an advocacy strategy is built and how a result is measured.

IN THIS SESSION YOU WILL LEARN

- A consultant's daily work
- Career paths and indicative pay levels
- The difference between monitoring, advocacy and positioning
- Whether this job fits your profile

EU HEAD HUNTING AND THE JOB MARKET

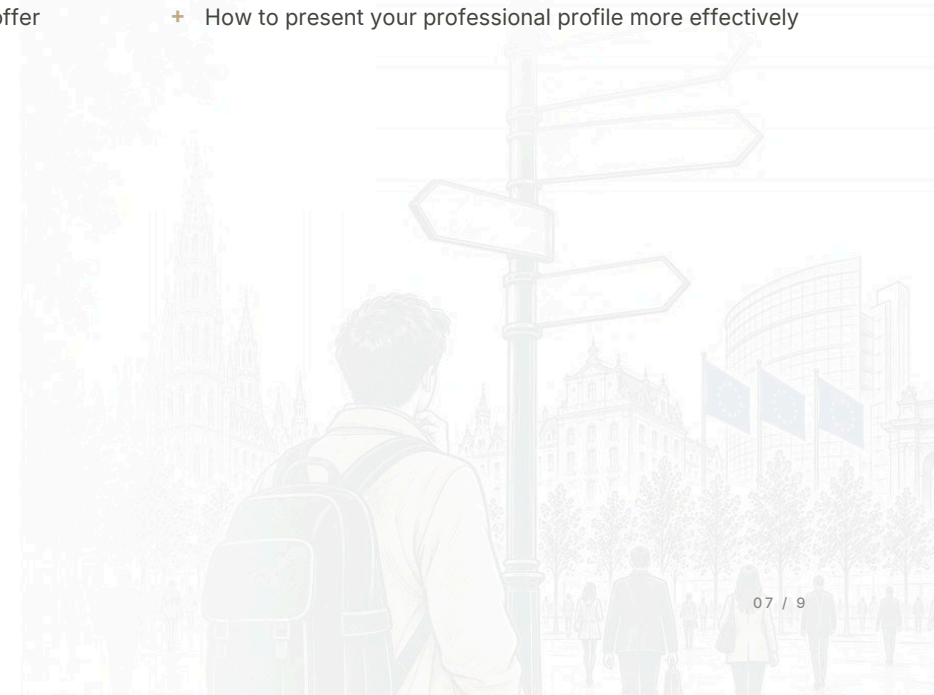
ROBERTO ZANGRANDI

How the European job market looks at candidates: what is visible in a CV in the first thirty seconds.

How a search is run, what makes a profile placeable and what holds it back. The market: profiles in demand, salary levels, mobility between parts of the ecosystem. How to prepare for an interview and how to negotiate an offer.

IN THIS SESSION YOU WILL LEARN

- How your CV is actually read
- How to prepare an interview and negotiate an offer
- Which profiles are scarce and which abundant in Brussels
- How to present your professional profile more effectively



EU FUNDING AND PROJECT DESIGN

LORENZO COSTANTINO

How to read a call for proposals, build a partnership and write a fundable project.

The European programmes and how they are managed — directly, indirectly and under shared management. The anatomy of a real call: building the partnership and running the project. Who employs in this field — public bodies, agencies, consultancies, universities, NGOs — which roles they offer and how to approach them.

IN THIS SESSION YOU WILL LEARN

- The anatomy of a call for proposals
- How a project partnership is put together
- The difference between project design and management
- How to get into the EU funding sector

IN-HOUSE LOBBYING: EU AFFAIRS INSIDE A COMPANY

ROBERTO PANICO

How a company's interests are represented in Brussels, and how it differs from consultancy work.

The European affairs office of a large group: monitoring, direct advocacy, institutional relations, events. How a corporate position is formed, and how trade associations and coalitions come into it. The profiles companies look for and the ways into an in-house EU team.

IN THIS SESSION YOU WILL LEARN

- How a corporate EU affairs office works
- How a company position is built and defended
- In-house versus consultancy, in concrete terms
- Career paths into corporate roles

EU JOURNALISM AND INSTITUTIONAL COMMUNICATION

RAFFAELLA DE MARTE

How Europe is reported from the outside and communicated from within.

How a European news story is built, spread and fact-checked. The ways into European journalism: internships, freelancing, competitions, agencies, press offices. How an institutional communicator informs the public and represents the position of their institution. Fake news and the defence of the EU institutions and democratic processes.

IN THIS SESSION YOU WILL LEARN

- How to make a complex European topic accessible to a wide audience
- How a European institution communicates, and under what constraints
- How careers in institutional communication and EU journalism are evolving
- Recognising disinformation and political framing about the EU

NGOS AND EUROPEAN CIVIL SOCIETY

IGNAZIO CORRAO

How advocacy works without commercial interests behind it, and how to move from the institutions to civil society.

The landscape of NGOs and European networks, and how they work with the institutions. How an advocacy campaign is built with limited resources. The profiles in demand and the real working conditions of the sector.

IN THIS SESSION YOU WILL LEARN

- How a European NGO works and how it is funded
- How to build a campaign with limited resources
- The real conditions of the European third sector
- The soft and interpersonal skills that help you enter this sector

PRACTICAL INFORMATION

SPRING PROGRAMME 2027. HOW TO APPLY.

Duration	6 days, Monday to Saturday
Language	Italian (part of the programme may be held in English)
Location	Avenue des Arts 50, Brussels (European quarter)
Group size	16 to 25 participants
Fee	€ 1,370 per person, VAT incl.
Included	All ten modules, programme materials and two networking moments
Not included	Travel, accommodation and meals

THE THREE 2027 EDITIONS

PROGRAMME	DATES	DEADLINE TO APPLY
Programme I	12–17 April 2027	**19 February 2027**
Programme II	24–29 May 2027	**2 April 2027**
Programme III	14–19 June 2027	**23 April 2027**

HOW SELECTION WORKS

Applications are submitted through the IteraLab Student Application Form, together with a CV and, optionally, a short motivation letter. Admission is decided on the merit of the application. Places on each edition are limited, so the date of submission is taken into account as well: applying early gives the strongest chance of a place.

WANT TO KNOW MORE?

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